

clan. Once a woman married she could wear the *boqta*—a unique headdress reaching over five feet in height. When Marco Polo took the *boqta* back to Europe, fashion-conscious medieval women eagerly imitated it and wore cone-shaped headdresses known as hennins.

Creating an empire

For centuries the Mongols fought among themselves and raided neighboring areas. Genghis Khan united all the tribes under his leadership in 1206, thereby founding the Mongol Empire, after which he was hailed as “Great Khan.” Genghis Khan and his descendants embarked on a series of campaigns in which they conquered over 9 million square miles of territory extending from the Pacific to Central Europe. The majority of the Mongol Horde was male, although some women did go on campaigns and a few even served as commanders. Most women stayed at home and, while their men were

away, some elite females became highly influential in Mongol society. Börte, the senior wife of Genghis Khan, was the first Grand Empress to help govern in her husband’s absence. Sorghaghtani later became the most prominent Mongol woman (see right); her son Kublai became Great Khan in 1260 and, through conquest, Emperor of China in 1271. Kublai’s wife Chabi was his most trusted adviser; she helped integrate China into his realms, promoted Buddhism, and may have helped advance the career of Marco Polo in China. Chabi epitomized the high status of Mongol women and played a major role in the creation of the largest contiguous land empire in history.

▼ Sharing the throne

Even though men were dominant, women had a considerable degree of power and freedom in Mongol society. This 14th-century miniature depicts Emperor Ghazan seated on his throne with his principal wife Kököchin beside him.



BIOGRAPHY

SORGHAGHTANI

The most powerful woman in Mongol history, Sorghaghtani married Genghis Khan’s youngest son Tolui. When he died in 1232 she ruled his lands, and became a trusted adviser to Genghis’s successors, governing while they were away on campaign. She took advantage of succession disputes during the 1240s to maneuver her oldest son Möngke into power. He became Great Khan in 1251. Her final triumph saw her foiling a plot to assassinate him. She died soon after.

